

The Games You Can Play From This Book

Every game in the book a reader can actually sit down and play, with what Culin leaves out said plainly.

Most of the ninety-seven entries in Culin's book describe a game without quite telling you how to play it. A few tell you completely, and this is the list of those — with what he supplies, what he leaves out, and what a modern player needs to add to sit down and play. Where something has to be supplied it is said so; nothing here is presented as Culin's when it is not.

The boards are on the companion sheets, at playing size, free.

Nyout · yut, yunnori · game LXX

The board. Twenty-nine marks. Twenty are set at equal distances round a circle; nine more make a cross inside it, four on each diameter and one shared at the centre. Culin says it is drawn on a sheet of paper or scratched on the ground, which is why there is no such thing as an old nyout board to put in a museum. **The dice.** Four blocks of wood, white and flat on one side, black and convex on the other, thrown together. Culin gives the counts and they are not simply the number of white faces: four white is *nyout* and counts 4, three white *kel* 3, two *kǎi* 2, one *to* 1 — and four BLACK, that is none white at all, is *mo* and counts 5, the best throw in the game. A block landing on its end counts as black. There is no cube and no pip anywhere in it. **Players.** Two, three or four. With four, the players sitting opposite are partners, and a player may move his partner's pieces. **The move.** The men, called *mal*, “horses”, enter on the mark next to the left of the one carrying the character *ch'ut* and go round from left to right, against the sun. A man that stops exactly on a quarter mark may cut across the cross instead of going on round, which is the whole tactical content of the game: the diagonal is short and the circle is long, and the throws decide whether you get the chance. **Doubling.** If your throw lands one of your men on another of your own, you may double them up and take them round as one piece thereafter — though they still count as two. Culin gives the Korean name for a piece at each stage of doubling, which tells you how ordinary the manoeuvre was. **Taking.** A man landing on a mark held by an opponent “catches” it — *tjap-et-ta* — and that man must be started again from the beginning. Catching earns you another throw. So does a throw of *nyout* or *mo*, taken before you move; and if you throw *nyout* or *mo* and then anything else, you may split the two throws between two men. **Winning.** Get your horses round the circle and out past the entry mark, one more than the exact count being needed to take a man off; an excess does not matter. How many horses that means is agreed before you start: with two players, one or four as agreed; with three, three each; with four, four to the winning side. **What you must supply.** Almost nothing, which is why this is the first game in the guide. Culin does not say what happens when a man is caught on a doubled pair, and he does not give the modern scoring conventions of *yut*.

HOW COMPLETE CULIN'S ACCOUNT IS

Yes — this is the fullest description in the book, and the one game you can play from these pages without settling anything yourself.

Kon-tjil · gonu · game LXXX

The Korean relative of the game English speakers call nine men's morris — and it is a relative rather than the same game, which is worth saying because the differences are easy to read straight past. Three squares one inside another, joined by lines at the midpoints of the sides; twenty-four points where lines meet. Culin gives the Chinese name as *Sam k'i*, “three chess”. **First phase.** The players put down a piece alternately on any empty point, and keep going until all twenty-four points are occupied — so each side places twelve men, not the nine of the European game. Three of your own in a line takes an enemy man, but the man is not lifted: you mark it dead by standing one of your own men on top of it, and it stays on the board until the board is full. **Second phase.** When every point is occupied the dead men are cleared away, and the players move in turn, one space at a time along a line to an empty point. Three in a line still takes an enemy man. **Winning.** Culin's condition is either taking the opponent's men or blocking them so that they cannot move. He does not name a number of men at which a player is beaten. **What you must supply.** Whether a player reduced to three men may “fly” to any empty point, which is the usual mercy rule in the European game and is not in Culin; and whether a man standing on a dead man may itself be taken.

HOW COMPLETE CULIN'S ACCOUNT IS

Yes, and it is more complete than it looks — but do not play it from memory of nine men's morris. The men are twelve a side, and a captured man stays on the board under its captor until the board fills.

The kono family · gonu · games LXXVI–LXXIX

Four small line games — well kono, four-field, five-field and six-field — played on scratched diagrams with pebbles, beans or coins. Culin gives each a paragraph, which is enough for the diagram and the object but not always for the capture rule. **Well kono** is the one that plays best cold: a small diagram with a “well” at one point, two men a side, and the object of blocking your opponent so that they cannot move. It is a game about denial rather than capture and it takes about a minute to learn. **What you must supply.** For the field konos, whether capture is by leaping (as in draughts) or by approach. Culin's wording will support either on more than one of them, and this edition does not decide it for him.

HOW COMPLETE CULIN'S ACCOUNT IS

Partly.

Ssang-ryouk · ssangnyuk · game LXXIII

Backgammon, with two dice and fifteen men a side, on a board Culin reports as essentially the familiar one. If you can play backgammon you can play this; the differences he notes are in the entering and bearing-off conventions rather than in the shape of the game. **What you must supply.** The doubling and the exact bearing-off rule. Neither is in the text and neither existed in the modern form in 1893.

HOW COMPLETE CULIN'S ACCOUNT IS

In outline.

Pa-tok · baduk, go · game LXXV

It is go. Culin identifies it correctly with Chinese *wei-ch'i* and Japanese go, describes the board, and does not attempt a full ruleset — sensibly, because the rules were and are available elsewhere. Read the chapter for what it is: a report on how go was played in Korea in the 1890s, including the handicap conventions, which is the part hardest to find elsewhere.

HOW COMPLETE CULIN'S ACCOUNT IS

No, and it does not need to be.

Tjyang-keui · janggi · game LXXIV

Korean chess, by a man who played it. The board is the Chinese one with the files carried across the river, so the river has no effect; the king starts in the centre of his palace rather than on its back rank; the men are octagonal and graded in size by value, which means you can read the position from across the room. Wilkinson gives the moves, the palace restrictions and the differences from Chinese chess in enough detail to play. What he does not give — and modern *janggi* has — is the *bikjang* convention by which the two kings may agree a draw by facing each other, and the point-count scoring used to settle drawn games.

HOW COMPLETE CULIN'S ACCOUNT IS

Yes — Wilkinson gives a working account.

What cannot be played from this book · ·

It is worth being as clear about the failures as about the successes, because a playing guide that lists only what works is not a guide, it is advertising. **The tablet games** (LXXXI–LXXXIX) cannot be played from these pages. Culin names them, describes the tablets, and gives the shape of several games, but not the scoring — and a domino game without its scoring is a set of objects, not a game. The divining procedures are described more fully than the games, which tells you where his interest lay. **The card games** (XC–XCII) are worse off, because the pack itself has gone. *Tong-tang* is described at length and you could reconstruct the play, but you would first have to make eighty cards in eight suits of ten from Culin's description of their faces, and he is describing highly conventionalised written characters he could not read. **The lottery** (XCIII) is not a game to be played but a system to be understood, and the chapter understands it. **The last four entries** (XCIV–XCVII) are riddles and word games in Korean, and they do not survive translation at all. Culin prints them because his catalogue was a catalogue; they are here for the same reason. In short: of the twenty-eight games in this volume, six can be played tonight, six can be reconstructed with effort, and the rest are a record of games rather than instructions for them. That ratio is normal for nineteenth-century ethnography and it is not a criticism of Culin. It is the difference between a man writing down what he was told and a man writing a rulebook, and he was doing the first.

HOW COMPLETE CULIN'S ACCOUNT IS

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